



PRESIDENT MEETS KING OF MALAYSIA

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan welcomed Sultan Ibrahim Ibni Almarhum Sultan Iskandar, King of Malaysia, who is on a working visit to the UAE. During the meeting at Qasr Al Bahr in Abu Dhabi, the leaders exchanged warm and cordial remarks reflecting the strength of ties between their nations and expressed their mutual wishes for continued progress and prosperity for both countries, as well as further growth in UAE-Malaysia relations.

Coffee consumption in the UAE accelerates, bucking global trend

Strong café culture keeps coffee demand rising as global habits shift

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Coffee consumption in the UAE is accelerating, in line with wider growth across the GCC, bucking a global trend in which rising prices are forcing consumers to rethink how they buy their daily cup. While coffee drinkers in the US and Europe are increasingly switching to home brewing, cheaper formats, and private-label brands as global prices surge, demand in the UAE continues to rise. The local coffee market, valued at more than Dh12 billion, is underpinned by one of the world's highest rates of out-of-home consumption,

The momentum will be on display when World of Coffee Dubai returns in January 2026, with the event expanding fourfold since 2022 as the region's coffee ecosystem matures.

with cafés and restaurants accounting for about 93 per cent of total spending. Globally, arabica prices have climbed to record highs after supply disruptions and poor weather in Brazil, pushing up prices and reshaping consumer behaviour in mature markets. Surveys show millions of drinkers are trading down rather than cutting consumption altogether, opting for convenience-led or lower-cost options. The UAE, by contrast, stands out. Operators have largely absorbed higher costs through

scale, efficiency, and premium positioning, allowing café culture to continue expanding across Dubai and other emirates.

Rising green coffee imports
Growth is also being reinforced by rising green coffee imports into the GCC and Dubai's growing role as a regional logistics and re-export hub, with coffee re-export values topping Dh3.5 billion last year. The momentum will be on display when World of Coffee Dubai returns in January 2026, with the event expanding fourfold since 2022 as the region's coffee ecosystem matures.

As global prices remain elevated, the UAE's experience highlights a different trajectory. Coffee consumption is not slowing. It is accelerating, driven by infrastructure, investment, and a consumer base that continues to prioritise experience and quality.

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Ronaldo to attend Globe Soccer Awards in Dubai

Al Nassr star nominated for an award

DUBAI
BY SHAMSEER MOHAMMED
Staff Writer

Cristiano Ronaldo is coming to Dubai for the prestigious Globe Soccer Awards, taking place on December 28 at the luxurious Atlantis Royal hotel. The event promises a spectacular evening celebrating football's biggest stars and emerging talents from around the world.

Ronaldo's presence has particularly excited fans, as the Al Nassr superstar is shortlisted in the Best Middle East Player category. He faces stiff competition from fellow Saudi Pro League

stars, including Al Hilal's Salem Al Dawsari, former Real Madrid teammate Karim Benzema of Al Ittihad, and Riyadh Mahrez of Al Ahli.

The awards ceremony will showcase global football excellence with several award categories, including the Best Men's Player award, which features an impressive lineup. Barcelona's superstar Lamine Yamal, Real Madrid's Kylian Mbappe, and heavily underrated Raphinha are all in contention, alongside Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele. On the women's side, Barcelona's Aitana Bonmati is eyeing a historic third consecutive Best Women's Player award.

UAE injects Dh33b to boost tourism, jobs

'OUR WINTER IS ENTREPRENEURIAL' THEME TARGETS FUNDING GOALS

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

The UAE is leveraging its booming tourism sector to create jobs, foster innovation, and empower entrepreneurs, supported by over Dh33 billion in national funding programmes.

Tourism, which contributes significantly to GDP, has emerged as a cornerstone of the UAE's economic diversification strategy, attracting millions of global visitors annually and driving growth in hospitality, retail, transport, and leisure industries.

The World's Coolest Winter campaign, themed "Our winter is entrepreneurial", highlights how government-backed funds are enabling start-ups and SMEs to tap into this vibrant sector. By providing financing, training, advisory services, and incubation support, these initiatives ensure businesses not only survive but thrive, while generating employment opportunities across the country.

Key enabler

The Khalifa Fund for Enterprise Development, established in Abu Dhabi in 2007, has been a key enabler, supporting more than 1,200 companies with over Dh1.4 billion in funding and creating 15,000 jobs. Its start-up and expansion programmes cover up to 80 per cent of project costs.

1,200

firms the Khalifa Fund for Enterprise Development has aided in Abu Dhabi

Dubai's Mohammed Bin Rashid Establishment for SME Development has funded 168 projects worth Dh137 million since 2015, with plans to support 27,000 Emirati businesses by 2033. It provides a comprehensive platform of planning, accelerators, training, marketing, licensing, financing, and access to government procurement.

Sharjah's RUWAD Foundation, part of the Sharjah Economic Development Department, focuses on nurturing SMEs and Emirati entrepreneurial talent. It has trained 9,724 participants, financed 106 projects.

The Emirates Development Bank (EDB), operational since 2015, has disbursed Dh30 billion to more than 13,500 companies, contributing Dh10 billion to national GDP.

Together, these funding programmes and initiatives are building a thriving entrepreneurial ecosystem, driving job creation, diversifying the economy, and positioning the UAE as a leading global destination for tourism and investment.

NATION

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Wish you a

Merry Christmas & Happy New Year

Thankyou all